

ECONOMIC SOCIOLOGY

OVERVIEW

The aim of this course is to provide you with an introduction to economic sociology, a subfield of sociology. Broadly defined, economic sociology is the study of economic life. Economic sociologists focus on different levels of analysis, from individuals and organizations to whole economic fields and states.

What I want you to take away from this class is hopefully a new perspective and curiosity on our economic life, our social life, and their interrelation. What do each consist of? How do they relate and interact with one another? What are the consequences of these interactions? These questions constitute the course's throughline and I encourage you to keep them in mind as we engage with the course materials.

The reading list for the course is a mixture of classic works and more recent exemplars. Sustained and critical engagement with these materials is the core of this course. As such, I ask that you do the readings before class and come prepared for a discussion. While I will deliver a lecture, I would like to treat the class more as a reading group where we can exchange ideas respectfully and energetically. This goal orients the course's components - details below.

COMPONENTS

There are four key components in this course: In-class participation (20%), weekly responses (40%), a short presentation (10%), and a final assignment (30%).

- I. **Attendance and Participation (20%):** You are required to attend class regularly (10%) and actively participate in discussions (10%). Please let me know ahead of time (at least one day) if you cannot attend class for any reasons. You are allowed two unexcused absences.

Regarding in-class participation: Your participation should be first and foremost respectful. It should show clear engagement with the readings and/or with your peers. One thing that I always encourage is to ask as many clarifying questions as needed--They are an important part of learning and even more so given the sometimes theoretically dense readings. I also welcome bringing in perspectives from the different disciplines outside of sociology. However, it will be incumbent on you to succinctly explain these references to those of us who are

unfamiliar, and their relevance to the discussion at hand.

- II. **Weekly response (40%):** You are required to submit 10 weekly responses to the readings of the upcoming week, each worth 4% for a total of 40%. There are 12 chances for you to submit, and I encourage you to do all 12 (I will take the highest 10 for the final grade).

In my experience, these responses are very generative to the class, and I regularly rely on them to prepare my lecture. Weekly responses help inform all other assignments. That it weighs the most grade wise reflects the importance of this sustained engagement.

The estimated length of the response should be about 500-600 words. This assignment starts from the second week and is **due every Monday night BEFORE class**.

For each of the readings for the week, please consider and answer the following questions (You should jot down rough answers to these questions as you do the readings):

- (a) What is the question/puzzle that the authors are trying to answer?
- (b) With whom is the author arguing against/adding to? Briefly explain the existing arguments/positions.
- (c) What are the author's main arguments and, briefly, what is the evidence used to support said argument?
- (d) At least one question that you have regarding the reading.

Some pending details to be decided in the first class.

- III. **Short presentation (10%):** You are required to deliver a short 15-minute presentation on the readings for the week that focuses on questions (a) and (b) in your weekly response. In other words: The presentation should start with the puzzle the authors were grappling with, followed by a discussion of the existing answers to those puzzles at the time.

This assignment is designed to encourage you to examine more deeply the context of an argument and the audience to whom the authors were communicating. These elements are crucial to understanding the authors' own arguments.

Note: This may be a group assignment depending on the number of students in the class.

- IV. **Final assignment (30%):** Finally, at the end of the term, you are required to choose two among five (2/5) prompts and

write a response, each no longer than 1,500 words.

The assignment is broken down into two parts: The first is an outline for your responses. This is worth 10% and is due **by the end of week 14**. The second is the responses themselves, worth 10% each for a total of 20%, and due on **December 18th**. Below are the five prompts that you can choose from:

1. What is embeddedness? Explain why (or why not) this is an important concept and give examples of embeddedness in action using the materials we have covered in class.
2. How do social relations impact economic outcomes? Compare the similarities and differences in how different social relations operate and influence our economic lives.
3. Discuss the role of culture in economic actions.
4. Discuss the role of power in economic actions.
5. How are economic ideas constructed and applied to different social domains? What are the complications of this process?

RESOURCES:

Writing Guide: Writing for Sociology [[link](#)]

Citation: Zotero Guide from the library [[link](#)]

ADMINISTRATIVE ISSUES

Academic integrity: Cheating on exams and plagiarism on written assignments are not tolerated. Please familiarize yourself with the university's policy. Be sure to use quotation marks when using direct quotes and cite accordingly when quoting (or paraphrasing) someone else's words. Failure to comply will result in automatic failure of the assignment and a report to the Dean and the Committee on Academic Integrity.

AI policies: I generally discourage the use of AI for this class and more generally for your studies. While there are ways to use AI to enhance learning, I do not think it is the case for this class, for which an auxiliary aim is to get you to practice engaging more deeply with a complicated text. This experience can be frustrating. However, I think it will enhance your critical thinking and in the long run actually help you use AI more productively as a tool, rather than become dependent on it.

Accommodations: ...

GRADING POLICIES

Grading scale:

A=100-94; A-=93-91
B+=90-88; B=87-84; B-=83-81
C+=80-78; C=77-74; C-=73-71
D+=70-68; D=67-61
F=60 and below.

Late assignments: Please speak with me or email me prior to the due date of an assignment if an extension is needed. With no communication, assignments will automatically lose 5% then 10% for each additional day late.

Grade concerns: If you wish to challenge a grade, please: (1) wait 24 hours after receiving your score, (2) email me a short summary of your concerns, refer to the assignment requirements and instructor feedback, and (3) wait for my reply so we can set up an appointment to meet.

COURSE OUTLINE AND MATERIALS

All materials are accessible via Google Drive [\[link\]](#)

Week 1: Introduction

In the first week we set the agenda for the term. We will make our acquaintance with economic sociology by comparing the sociological approach to economic life with that by economists. I will also cover some related fundamental sociological ideas.

Week 1 readings:

Syllabus.

Hirsch, Paul, Stuart Michaels, and Ray Friedman. 1987.

"'Dirty Hands' versus 'Clean Models': Is Sociology in Danger of Being Seduced by Economics?" *Theory and Society* 16(3):317-36.

Smith, Adam. 1759. *The Theory of Moral Sentiments*. Read: "The poor man's son." [\[link\]](#): long para starting with "The poor man's son, whom heaven in its anger has visited with ambition..."].

Supplementary materials:

Berger, Peter L., and Thomas Luckmann. 1966. *The Social Construction of Reality: A Treatise in the Sociology of Knowledge*. Read: "Origins of Institutionalization" (pp. 70-85).

Mills, Charles Wright. 1959. *The Sociological Imagination*. Read: "The Promise" (pp. 3-24). Students are encouraged to

also read Chapter 2: "Grand Theory" (pp. 25-49).
Silbey, Susan. *Invocations of Law on Snowy Streets*. [[link](#)].

Week 2: Embeddedness

In the second week, we tackle "embeddedness," a central concept in economic sociology. We will read Karl Polanyi's formulation of embeddedness through excerpts of his famous 1944 book, "The Great Transformation." We will proceed to look at a more modern variation of this argument through Granovetter's seminal 1985 paper. This idea of embeddedness will continue to stay with us for the rest of the course as we encounter its various manifestations in different contexts.

Week 2 readings:

- Granovetter, Mark. 1985. "Economic Action and Social Structure: The Problem of Embeddedness." *American Journal of Sociology* 91(3):481-510.
- Polanyi, Karl. 2001. *The Great Transformation: The Political and Economic Origins of Our Time*. Boston, Mass: Beacon Press. Read: The introduction to the book by Fred Block (pp.xviii-xxxvii) and Chapter 4: "Societies and Economic Systems" (pp.45-58).

Weeks 3 & 4: Social Relations

Across these two weeks we will examine how social relations matter for economic actions and outcomes, i.e., an expression of embeddedness. In week 3, we will see this in two domestic, competitive markets--the job market and the textile market in the United States. In week 4, we turn instead to the transnational financial markets to see how international capital flows are dependent on social relations.

Week 3 readings:

- Granovetter, Mark. 1973. "The Strength of Weak Ties." *American Journal of Sociology* 78(6):1360-1380.
- Uzzi, Brian. 1996. "The Sources and Consequences of Embeddedness for the Economic Performance of Organizations: The Network Effect." *American Sociological Review* 61(4):674-98. doi:[10.2307/2096399](https://doi.org/10.2307/2096399).

Week 4 readings:

- Harrington, Brooke. 2016. *Capital without Borders: Wealth Managers and the One Percent*. Cambridge, Mass: Harvard University Press. Read: Chapter 2: "Wealth Management as a Profession," and parts of chapter 3: "Client Relations"

(pp.36-105).

Hoang, Kimberly Kay. 2018. "Risky Investments: How Local and Foreign Investors Finesse Corruption-Rife Emerging Markets." *American Sociological Review* 83(4):657-85. doi:10.1177/0003122418782476.

Supplementary materials:

Hoang, Kimberly Kay. 2022. *Spiderweb Capitalism: How Global Elites Exploit Frontier Markets*. Princeton: Princeton University Press. Read: [TBD].

Rivera, Lauren A. 2016. *Pedigree: How Elite Students Get Elite Jobs*. Princeton: Princeton University Press. Read: [TBD].

Weeks 5 & 6: Gender and Race

Across these two weeks we will discuss the interference of specific types of social relations in the rational market. In week 5, we discuss gender dynamics. In week 6, we discuss race. Note, however, that these issues are never standalone: They intersect with one another and with other dynamics.

Week 5 readings:

Acker, Joan. 1990. "Hierarchies, Jobs, Bodies: A Theory of Gendered Organizations." *Gender and Society* 4(2):139-58.

Hoang, Kimberly Kay. 2015. *Dealing in Desire: Asian Ascendancy, Western Decline, and the Hidden Currencies of Global Sex Work*. Read: Introduction (pp.1-18); pp.39-77.

Radhakrishnan, Smitha. 2022. *Making Women Pay: Microfinance in Urban India*. Read: Introduction (pp.13-35).

Week 6 readings:

Korver-Glenn, Elizabeth. 2018. "Compounding Inequalities: How Racial Stereotypes and Discrimination Accumulate across the Stages of Housing Exchange." *American Sociological Review* 83(4):627-56. doi:10.1177/0003122418781774.

Silva, Fabiana. 2018. "The Strength of Whites' Ties: How Employers Reward the Referrals of Black and White Jobseekers." *Social Forces* 97(2):741-68. doi:10.1093/sf/soy051.

Week 7: Culture

In week 7, we discuss the role of culture in economic life. Why are some economic transactions possible while others are not? How did they become possible in the first place? Here we explore the ever haunting spectre of social meaning and social logic in

supposedly purely economic and rational markets.

Week 7 readings:

Zelizer, Viviana A. 2011. *Economic Lives: How Culture Shapes the Economy*. Princeton: Princeton University Press. Read: Introduction (pp.1-12); Chapter 1: "Human values and the market" (pp.19-39); Chapter 5: "The social meaning of money" (pp.93-127). The online version of the book is available at JSTOR, accessible from BC Libraries.

Weeks 8 & 9: Rational (?) Organizations

For these weeks, we will discuss the rational organization, epitomized by the corporation. But are they really rational? In week 8 we will discuss Meyer and Rowan's classic paper on formal institutions as "myth and ceremony," centering on the role of culture and the institutional environment. In week 9, we will start to see how "power" starts to make an appearance

Week 8 readings:

Meyer, John W., and Brian Rowan. 1977. "Institutionalized Organizations: Formal Structure as Myth and Ceremony." *American Journal of Sociology* 83(2):340-63.

Week 9 readings:

DiMaggio, Paul J., and Walter W. Powell. 1983. "The Iron Cage Revisited: Institutional Isomorphism and Collective Rationality in Organizational Fields." *American Sociological Review* 48(2):147-60. doi:[10.2307/2095101](https://doi.org/10.2307/2095101).
Roy, William G. 1997. *Socializing Capital: The Rise of the Large Industrial Corporation in America*. Princeton, N.J: Princeton University Press. Read: "Introduction" (pp. 3-20); Chapter 3: "The Corporation as Public and Private Enterprise" (pp. 41-77).

Weeks 10-12: Economic Ideas

Lurking behind the materials we will have covered thus far in the course is the idea that the economic field itself and its application are perhaps socially constructed: A "market ideology" broadly taken for granted. But why and how? For weeks 10-12, we will entertain this argument and examine how the economic logic and methods have proliferated in different ways in different social arenas.

The first theme is around "performativity," the idea that economic models are acted out and self-fulfilling rather than rooted in empirical reality. In week 11, we consider a key

element in economic rationale: Commensuration, when the unquantifiable becomes quantified. Finally, week 12 presents the current economization of climate change.

Week 10 readings:

- Carruthers, B. G. 2013. "From Uncertainty toward Risk: The Case of Credit Ratings." *Socio-Economic Review* 11(3):525-51. doi:[10.1093/ser/mws027](https://doi.org/10.1093/ser/mws027).
- MacKenzie, Donald, and Yuval Millo. 2003. "Constructing a Market, Performing Theory: The Historical Sociology of a Financial Derivatives Exchange." *American Journal of Sociology* 109(1):107-45. doi:10.1086/374404.

Week 11 readings:

- Espeland, Wendy Nelson, and Michael Sauder. 2007. "Rankings and Reactivity: How Public Measures Recreate Social Worlds." *American Journal of Sociology* 113(1):1-40. doi:[10.1086/517897](https://doi.org/10.1086/517897).
- Sauder, Michael, and Wendy Nelson Espeland. 2009. "The Discipline of Rankings: Tight Coupling and Organizational Change." *American Sociological Review* 74(1):63-82. doi:[10.1177/000312240907400104](https://doi.org/10.1177/000312240907400104).

Week 12 readings:

- Elliott, Rebecca. 2018. "The Sociology of Climate Change as a Sociology of Loss." *European Journal of Sociology* 59(3):301-37. doi:[10.1017/S0003975618000152](https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003975618000152).
- El Tinay, Hassan, and Juliet B. Schor. 2025. "Do Economists Think about Climate Change and Inequality? Semantic Analysis and Topic Modeling of Top Five Economics Journals." *Ecological Economics* 232:108548. doi:10.1016/j.ecolecon.2025.108548.
- Janković, Vladimir, and Andrew Bowman. 2014. "After the Green Gold Rush: The Construction of Climate Change as a Market Transition." *Economy and Society* 43(2):233-59. doi:[10.1080/03085147.2013.791511](https://doi.org/10.1080/03085147.2013.791511).

Supplementary materials:

- Espeland, Wendy Nelson, and Mitchell L. Stevens. 1998. "Commensuration as a Social Process." *Annual Review of Sociology* 24(1):313-43. doi:[10.1146/annurev.soc.24.1.313](https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.soc.24.1.313).

Week 13: The Global Diffusion of Economic Ideas

This week we will discuss how economic ideas and models travel internationally. We start with an extension of Meyer and Rowan's new institutionalist argument: The world society theory. We then

move onto a more complicated picture through Sarah Babb's work on the "Chicago Boys" economists in Mexico.

Week 13 readings:

- Babb, Sarah. 2004. *Managing Mexico: Economists from Nationalism to Neoliberalism*. Princeton: Princeton University Press. Read: Chapter 1, "Neoliberalism and the globalization of economic expertise" (pp.1-22).
- Meyer, John W., John Boli, George M. Thomas, and Francisco O. Ramirez. 1997. "World Society and the Nation-State." *American Journal of Sociology* 103(1):144-81. doi:[10.1086/231174](https://doi.org/10.1086/231174).

Supplementary materials:

- Fourcade-Gourinchas, Marion, and Sarah L. Babb. 2002. "The Rebirth of the Liberal Creed: Paths to Neoliberalism in Four Countries." *American Journal of Sociology* 108(3):533-79. doi:[10.1086/367922](https://doi.org/10.1086/367922).
- Kentikelenis, Alexander E., and Sarah Babb. 2019. "The Making of Neoliberal Globalization: Norm Substitution and the Politics of Clandestine Institutional Change." *American Journal of Sociology* 124(6):1720-62. doi:[10.1086/702900](https://doi.org/10.1086/702900).

Week 14 & 15: Financialization and its consequences [may change]
We will end the class with a movie and two sessions on financialization. We start with a documentary on the Great Financial Crisis of 08-09 to ease our way into the topic. In the last week of the class, we will read a review of the concept of financialization, and what I think is a very prescient couple of chapters by Giovanni Arrighi on the topic.

Week 14 movie:

Ferguson, Charles 2010. *Inside Job* (documentary)

Week 15 readings:

- van der Zwan, Natascha. 2014. "Making Sense of Financialization." *Socio-Economic Review* 12(1):99-129. doi:[10.1093/ser/mwt020](https://doi.org/10.1093/ser/mwt020).
- Arrighi, Giovanni, Beverly J. Silver, and Iftikhar Ahmad. 1999. *Chaos and Governance in the Modern World System*. Contradictions of Modernity. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press. Read: "Geopolitics and High Finance" (pp. 37-96).

Supplementary readings:

- Krippner, Greta R. 2005. "The Financialization of the

American Economy." *Socio-Economic Review* 3(2):173-208.
doi:[10.1093/SER/mwi008](https://doi.org/10.1093/SER/mwi008).